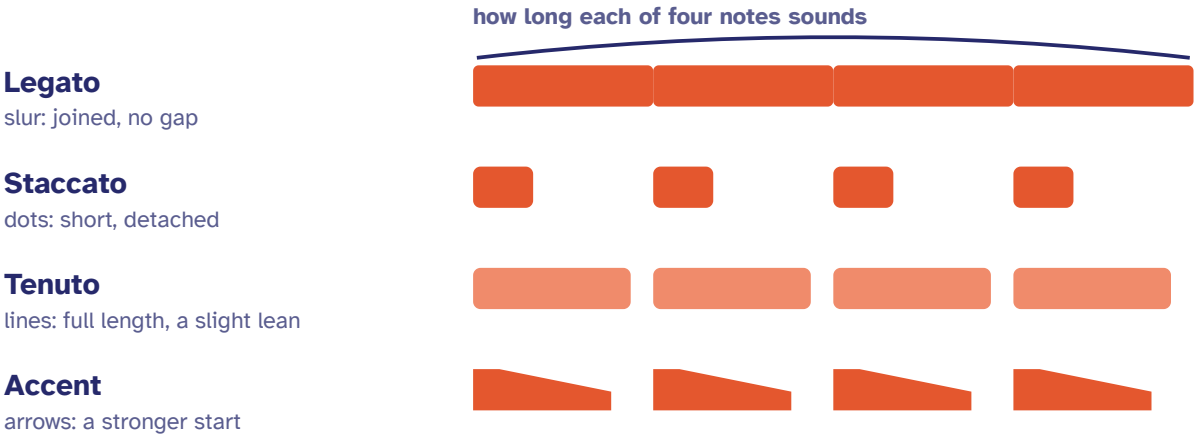
PART III · EXPRESSION · 2
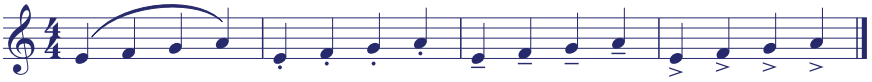
Touch: smooth, short, strong

The same four notes can sound smooth or bouncy, gentle or strong. Small marks above or below the notes tell your fingers how to touch the keys: this is **articulation**.

THE SECRET
Curve: join. Dot: short.
Line: hold. Arrow: strong.
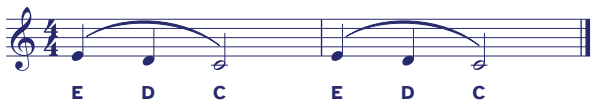


Same notes, four touches
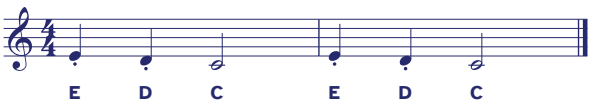


The same four notes: slurred, staccato, tenuto, accented.

MARK	NAME	HOW TO PLAY
⌒	**slur** (*legato*)	join the notes smoothly, no gap
●	**staccato**	short and detached: let go early
—	**tenuto**	hold the full length, leaning a little
>	**accent**	a stronger start to the note
▼	**staccatissimo**	very short *Extra*
^	**marcato**	very strong, marked *Extra*

Slurs and phrases



Slurred: join E D C, then a tiny lift.
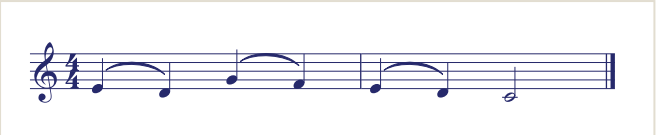


Staccato: every E and D let go early.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2 · CONTINUED

A curve over **different** notes is a slur: join them, then lift at its end, like a breath. A long slur over a whole line of tune is a **phrase mark**: one musical sentence. (A curve joining the **same** note twice is a tie, p. 53.)

Two-note slurs



A slur over just two notes is a little sigh: **drop** into the first note, then **lift** off the second, lighter and a little shorter. Drop, lift.
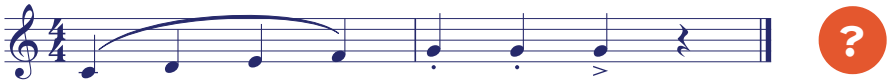
Mood words

Some words describe the mood, not the speed.

WORD	MEANING	WORD	MEANING
dolce	sweetly	*leggiero*	lightly
cantabile	in a singing style	*espressivo*	with feeling
legato	smoothly	*grazioso*	gracefully
maestoso	majestically	*con moto*	with movement

EXAMPLE 1

Which notes are short?
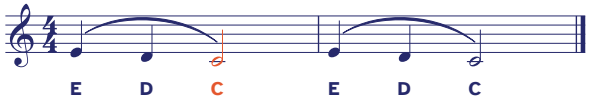


1. **Bar 1:** what does the curve ask?
2. **Bar 2:** find the dots.
3. **The last G** has a different mark: which?

Bar 1 is joined; the **two dotted Gs are short**; the third G is accented, stronger but full length.

EXAMPLE 2

How do you play the end of a slur?



1. **Join E D C** under the first curve.
2. **At the end of the curve:** hold, or lift?
3. **The next curve** starts on E again.

Join the notes, then **lift after the C**: a small breath before the next E, like a singer.

HOW TO
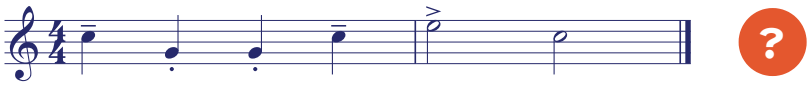
Practise touch

1. **Play one bar** of a piece three ways: all legato, all staccato, then as written.
2. **Listen:** can someone else hear which way was which?

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Line, dot or arrow?



1. **The first two Cs have lines:** how long?
2. **The Gs have dots.**
3. **The E in bar 2** has an arrow.

The first two Cs held their **full length**, the Gs short, the E strong, and the last C plain, held for its two beats.

GAME

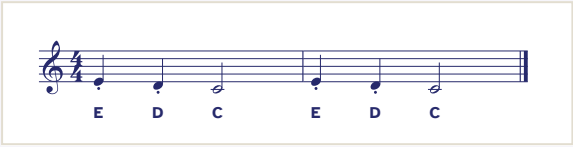
Name the touch

1	2	3	4
a dot	a line	>	a long curve

Name each mark and say how the note sounds.

Answer: 1 staccato, short · 2 tenuto, full and leaning · 3 accent, a strong start · 4 slur, joined (over different notes).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
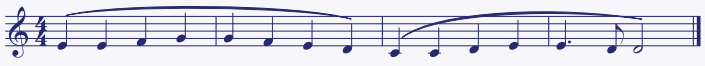


Hot Cross Buns, two ways.

Play E D C joined (fingers 3 2 1), then short and bouncy. Same notes, same fingers: two different tunes.

YOU KNOW THIS

Ode to Joy (Beethoven)



Two long slurs: two musical sentences. Lift your hand **only** at the end of each one, like a singer taking a breath.

Try it. Sing it and breathe only where the slurs end.

THINK OF IT Legato is walking: one foot leaves the ground as the other lands. Staccato is hopping on hot sand.

TRAP

- × Making staccato loud: short is not the same as strong.
- × Lifting in the middle of a slur: keep every note joined until the curve ends.

SEE ALSO

Loud and soft p. 73 · Tie or slur? p. 54

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Articulation